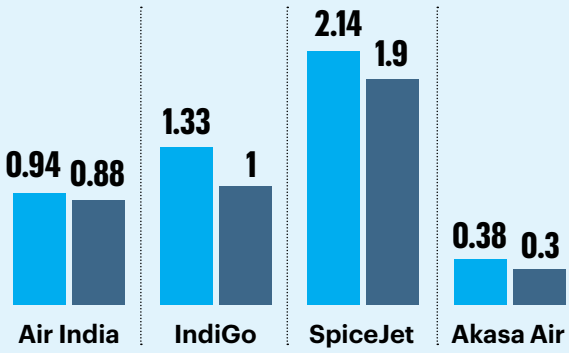
How India's top airlines fare on punctuality, cancellations and passenger complaints

CANCELLATIONS

Air India improves; IndiGo's higher cancellations reflect network strategy to maintain punctuality

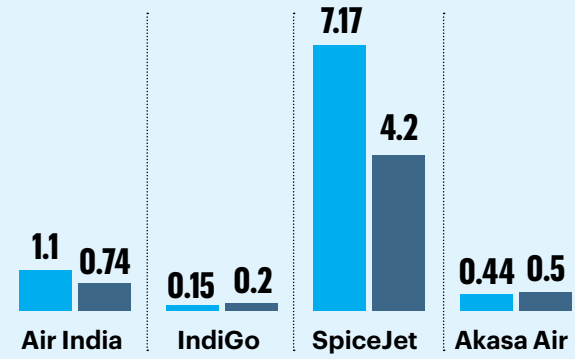
Average cancellation rate of scheduled flights (%)



COMPLAINTS

Air India sees fewer complaints in 2025; IndiGo and Akasa slip up but still fare better

Average monthly complaints per 10,000 passengers



Source: DGCA



"The Ahmedabad crash reinforces a broader industry learning seen in past cases like the Boeing 737 MAX [crashes in 2018–19]. That is, production and operational pressures can erode safeguards"

— PRAGYA PRIYADARSHINI
Managing Director, Primus Partners

was exploring alternatives, citing the need to respect "public sentiment" in India.

S.N. Bhatt, president of the Air India Aircraft Engineers Association, which represents engineers working with AIESL, rules out any "maintenance issue" with the Dreamliner fleet. "We follow the DGCA guidelines on replacement and repair. These are more rigid than the manufacturer's own guidelines," he says. Yet, internal documents show that on August 4, 2023, a London-bound Air India Dreamliner—similar to the one that crashed in Ahmedabad—was forced to return to Mumbai after an engine shut down during the climb. A fan blade in the engine's high-pressure section had broken loose, causing the failure. Investigators found the blade's locking lugs had been incorrectly installed in 2018, and had stayed that way.

Immediately after the Ahmedabad crash, the DGCA swung into action, ordering urgent inspections of all of Air India's 33 Dreamliners. In a June 25 statement, the airline said the regulator had completed inspections on 29 aircraft, all of which had been "cleared for service". Still, there's no getting around the fact that Air India has long struggled with technical and procedural lapses. Whistleblowers have added to this growing list of red flags. For instance, two former flight attendants have alleged their job was terminated for refusing to alter their testimony about an emergency slide that deployed mid-air in May 2024. Another case involves Captain Deven Kanani, who in 2023 reportedly raised concerns about insufficient oxygen supply aboard a Boeing 777 operating in an ultra-long-haul sector. According to aviation standards, such jets rely on chemically generated oxygen systems that provide just 12 minutes of breathable air in emergencies—a dangerously short window for, say, a Delhi-San Francisco flight, which often traverses high-altitude terrain. Following his complaint, the DGCA is learnt to have fined Air India Rs 1.1 crore in January 2024 even as the airline terminated Kanani's services.

On its part, Air India has consistently rejected all the allegations and the inherent claims about safety lapses whenever such controversies have broken out. For instance, in the case of the 'whistleblowers', the airline claimed the employees concerned indulged in "misconduct" that led to their termination. It also challenged the steep fines.